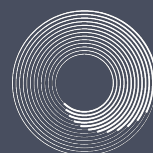




EXPERT GUIDE

5 reasons why PhD students delay & how-to avoid

Bärbel & Gunther Tress



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Congratulations, you are a PhD student!

Feels great doesn't it? You received that awesome PhD position at a prestigious university! Of course you're ecstatic, highly motivated, and looking optimistically ahead to the big things that are to come. If you started your PhD recently, you likely have a 3 or 4 year contract, at the end of which, you are supposed to turn in a dissertation that demonstrates that you have become an independent researcher in your own right! Although you will surely enjoy the process of undertaking your PhD, the not-so-good news is that it will likely take you (a lot) longer than you expect. The **vast majority of PhD students delay!**

Graduate schools give a lot of support to PhD students, but they also expect you to complete with a high quality dissertation on time. Exceeding your contract has consequences: The possibilities for an extension are restricted and you may struggle to get the finances together to bridge the time gap until you finally hand in the thesis. Imagine the stress and frustration this will cause you! But it is not only a serious blow to your self-confidence, it also puts your career and personal plans on hold!



While there are a wealth of factors that influence a delay, there are **5 common causes that affect most PhD students!** The good news is that **these are avoidable!** It is under your influence! Work actively on the steps we outline below and avoid a serious delay of your PhD project. **You can complete on time!** Yes, you can!

#1 Lack of a clear goal for your PhD project



"I was free to choose my own topic, but I found it too overwhelming. I did not have enough knowledge to choose the right track and I lost a lot of time over non-applicable ideas."

PhD student, Satellite engineering

This means you have **only a vague idea** of what exactly you want to accomplish in your PhD project. You lack an overall project goal and crystal clear objectives. There are four frequent reasons behind this :

- You came straight from a Masters Degree with little experience in research and you find it difficult to identify what is cutting edge, innovative or promising in your field. You postpone identifying a project goal, and lose time in the initial stage.
- You may not be aware of how important it is to define a clear research goal and to implement it. You start working somewhere and somehow, but you don't have a clear idea about the bigger picture, until later in your PhD.
- You have taken (deliberately or not) a step-by-step approach. You started with a single experiment, waited for the outcome, made a decision about how to go on, and so on.
- You are involved in a larger research project or programme, which has a project plan with a goal and objectives for the overall project, but it is not clear how your PhD project fits into this framework; there are no objectives specifically for your part.

The consequence of having no clear goal and starting work on it early is that you are **losing a lot of time** in the first phase, making it difficult to catch up. If even months after the start of your PhD project, you still have no clear idea what your project consists of, how are you going to achieve timely completion? Your success will be random.



Nobody just 'stumbles upon' meaningful research questions. It takes hard work and research to identify a project idea and develop it into specific research questions that form the foundation of your PhD. It will not come for free - you've got to start working on it.

✓ Actions:

- ▶ Read the key literature in your field to get a good overview what's going on. In order not to lose your way in the vast quantities of work available, clarify for yourself what you want to get out of reading a particular publication. Get a head start by asking your supervisors for key papers in your field.
- ▶ Brainstorm about potential project ideas and write them down, gradually narrowing down your choices.
- ▶ Formulate a broad overall research goal and then work out a set of coherent objectives that concisely add up to your goal.
- ▶ Discuss the early drafts of your goal and objectives with supervisors and colleagues. Take up their input, revise and refine.
- ▶ Consider this your main task at the start of your PhD. Until you have hammered out your project goal and objectives, everything else is a distraction.

#2 Embarking on a too large or too risky project



"I had to start all over again with my PhD after more than a year: For my project, I wanted to investigate a particular rare fish species. We'd been chasing it in the North Sea for a long time but could not track it."

PhD student, Marine biology

A project that is either too big or risky is an inadequate PhD project. If a project is **too big**, it can't be completed by one person in the standard time of 3-4 years. A project that is **too risky** involves experiments whose outcome is highly unpredictable. It can also be a project that includes overly high risks with logistics, data collection or data storage.

PhD students may choose projects that are too big or too risky because they are not aware of the risks, or overly optimistic and ambitious. But you may also



end up with a high-risk project because you (and your supervisors) have not sufficiently considered the time constraints of your PhD.

Projects that are too big or risky are ill-born from the start, and **difficult to fix**. You'll accumulate a serious delay, spend precious research money, and the project becomes unmanageable. Often, a major change in the original PhD plan is required - you'll have to start again from scratch.



Actions:

- ▶ Take a critical stance right from the start, by asking yourself: 'Can I do this in high quality within the given time?'
- ▶ Make sure you choose a project that's innovative and promising, but mainly safe.
- ▶ Carefully discuss with your supervisors. Ask them explicitly: "Do you think that this project is manageable for a PhD student (me) and will yield results within 3-4 years that merit a PhD degree? Some Graduate Schools require supervisors to check this!"
- ▶ If you have a great idea for a smaller risky experiment or aspect: design your project so that you have the main part on safe grounds (and might already earn your degree), then have one more risky aspect included in a later project phase. If it works out, it is the 'cherry on top' of your PhD, but never jeopardises its completion.

#3 Lack of planning



"I don't have a detailed plan for my PhD project yet, I will just start with a few different experiments and we'll see where it goes from there."

PhD student, Medicine

This refers to both the planning of the **entire project** and **daily planning**. Often, no project plan is written at all, it's in a rudimentary state, or you may have had an initial project plan, but it's never been updated. A project plan is the planning instrument that allows you to manage and control your project and steer it towards timely completion. But if you have completely wrong time estimates for the tasks your project plan, or your time-schedule is merely the result of wishful thinking, your project plan is pretty useless.

One consequence of not working with a project plan is that you never have an overview on: how the **project will unfold**, what its work units are, what skills



will be required at which point in time, when to fit in field work or course work, when to attend conferences and other meetings, how to organise the writing, etc... Without a project plan, landing where you are supposed to land after 3-4 years is highly unlikely. If nothing is fixed in writing in a project plan, you're open to random changes, drifting goals, and inviting spontaneous suggestions from supervisors.

'Lack of planning' also happens on a daily basis. It means you're unaware of what your **top priorities for the day** are and you're not used to working with **time-management techniques** to follow up on your priorities.

If you don't carefully plan your precious time, you drift in your workdays and over a longer period of time you will become **inefficient**. The days pass, but you don't cover a lot of ground. Day after day is filled with low priority tasks instead of you sharply focussing on what is most important to your project. After a while, you'll get the feeling that you are not making progress or accomplishing things. This often goes along with **a loss of motivation** and a **lack of purpose**.

✓ Actions:

- ▶ Take the time to set-up a complete project plan (5-10 pages) and discuss it with your supervisor(s). You'll need the whole shebang, not just a Gantt-chart as a result of blue sky thinking.
- ▶ If your supervisor is not a whiz at project management - attend a short & basic project management course.
- ▶ Update your plan 2-3 times a year. Use it to monitor your progress.
- ▶ Present it to your supervisors before your supervisory committee meetings, during which you discuss your progress and your future plans. If you detect a delay - your project plan has to be adapted to accommodate necessary changes.
- ▶ Get used to working with a task-manager (e.g. Todoist, Wunderlist) on a daily basis so you have an overview on all tasks (this is often sobering). You'll also have an overview on upcoming deadlines, and the importance of individual tasks to meet them.
- ▶ Upon the start of your work day, ask yourself: What is the single most important task that I can do for my PhD project today in order to complete on time?



#4 Lack of guidance



"My biggest challenge in my PhD is supervision, in the respect that there is none. I learn from my mistakes, but this takes an awful lot of time."

PhD student, Pharmacology

"My supervisor is difficult to handle. He communicates in a way which is lowering my self-esteem enormously and is extremely busy (not always easy to catch)."

PhD student, BioChemistry

Every PhD student is entitled to supervision. This is the main way you learn during your PhD studies. You'll have at least one, but more likely multiple supervisors or a supervisory team and it's great if you are able to draw from the experience of multiple people. **Good supervision is important**, as it affects the quality of your PhD and the quality of skills you acquire. However, you may still experience a lack of guidance. You might not have enough contact with your supervisor(s) or the quality of support is insufficient. Consequently, you don't get the structured feedback and pedagogically meaningful advice that would move your PhD project forward and towards a timely completion.

If you are contacting your supervisor time and time again for a meeting, but he/she is reluctant to meet with you or postpones one appointment after another, you'll likely be disappointed, feeling that you are not respected as a researcher or that your work seems irrelevant. In the long run you may get pretty frustrated and you give up on contacting your supervisor. Likewise, if you **don't get much out of meeting** with your supervisor, you likely become more self-reliant and withdraw from a collaborative way of working. In both cases there is a real danger that you may develop a mode of working, attitudes and approaches that do not fit with the mainstream practices of your discipline. Flaws and problems are often detected late and your work may lack the quality that only comes from critical exposure to experienced scientists' scrutiny.



Actions:

- ▶ Did you know that many PhDs have a say in who is appointed to their supervisory team? If you have the chance, make sure your voice is heard!
- ▶ Carefully select your main supervisor. Choose your main supervisor from the same institute or department so you can see each other regularly.



- ▶ Talk to previous PhD students or post-docs about a potential supervisor to hear their experience. Ideally he/she is an expert in your specific area, but also trained pedagogically, and supportive as a colleague.
- ▶ You can pick co-supervisors from other universities. Really try to go for the best expertise you can get internationally. Good co-supervisors are gold. They can help to outbalance weaknesses of your main supervisor and give additional input. They can also help to solve disputes or conflicts should they arise.
- ▶ Make sure you have regular planned and structured meetings with your main supervisor and additional meetings with your co-supervisors about your PhD project.
- ▶ Prepare for each meeting. Ask yourself: "What do I want to get out of the meeting? What are the reasons I want to see my supervisor(s)?" Be explicit about your requirements.
- ▶ If you do not understand their comments or suggestions - ask for clarification.
- ▶ If you are not happy with the supervision you get: Let your supervisor know what your problem is and how he/she could improve.

#5 Lack of focus on the PhD project



"At the Maths Institute, PhD students are required to be teaching assistants every semester. The workload for teaching is so high that I am far behind on absolutely everything with my PhD project."

PhD student, Mathematics

"At our institute we have a lot of additional work aside of the PhD. I am not able to work on my research topic for a few months as a result of the additional tasks and in such a case, I find it hard to 'pick up where I left off'.

PhD student, Physics

Lacking focus on your PhD project can occur in many different ways:

- Imagine, you worked on your project for some time and somehow it is losing its appeal. Other aspects suddenly seem to be much more interesting. Like an old pair of jeans, your project has lost it's newness and you want something new!



- You're constantly gaining new insights and so you may wish you'd chosen different aspects or approaches to your research. You follow up additional side projects or new ideas to bend your project towards what you would like to do.
- Your (international) network grows and you may be asked to join other projects and initiatives. You are flattered that someone finally realises the valuable skills you possess and you say yes!
- You are asked to take on regular teaching duties or other departmental tasks and you are eager to demonstrate that you are a mature member of the faculty, so you agree, only to realise a little later that it takes an immense amount of time - too much time - away from your PhD.

All of the above means that you are **doing extra work** that will ultimately delay your PhD. It's fabulous if you get some valuable additional experience during your PhD. But there's a difference between - let's say - teaching one or the other lecture or supervising a few students and taking on a regular teaching load. The time you have for the PhD is very limited and anything that distracts or poses a lot of extra work will ultimately delay you. In the end, you may have piled on all kinds of experience, but at what cost?

✓ Actions:

- ▶ Check in with yourself from time to time to identify whether you are still on track with your project and following up on your project's objectives.
- ▶ If you are tempted to take on additional responsibilities, figure out what the true reason behind it is: Are you dissatisfied with your project; is there a bigger problem? Are your additional duties just an excuse not to sort out your PhD project? In that case - it is better to solve the problems with your PhD first.
- ▶ Whenever you are asked to take on additional responsibilities, carefully consider if it's relevant for your PhD. Does the extra work justify the additional time you need to complete? Does it add expertise that will improve the quality of your project? Or can it significantly help you later on in your career? Really- does it?
- ▶ The PhD is not the end of your life, but the start of a professional career. It is likely more meaningful to complete your PhD on time and then follow up further project ideas in your first post-doc or other appointment.



We know: Delays *can* happen

One of the exciting aspects of doing a PhD is that you are investigating the unexplored, at the very edge of knowledge. And sometimes this can get messy. We know that there are **things beyond your control**: equipment breakage, technical problems, difficult working conditions, absent supervisors, illness... the list goes on. What's important is minimising unnecessary delays so when the unexpected happens, you have: a workable and developed project plan you can readily adjust, a schedule to keep you focused on important tasks and your supervisor's counsel and support.

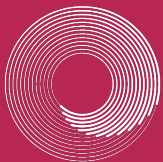
Imagine asking yourself one day in the future: "**How did I get a year (or more) behind with my PhD?**"

The answer is: One day at a time. Big delays do not happen overnight, they accumulate over time. The good news: You can influence this and **make a change every single day of your PhD!** Although life doesn't stop for your PhD, you can take action against the 5 most common causes for delay. Get working now & complete on time! We hope you have realised just how much influence you have over your PhD!

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